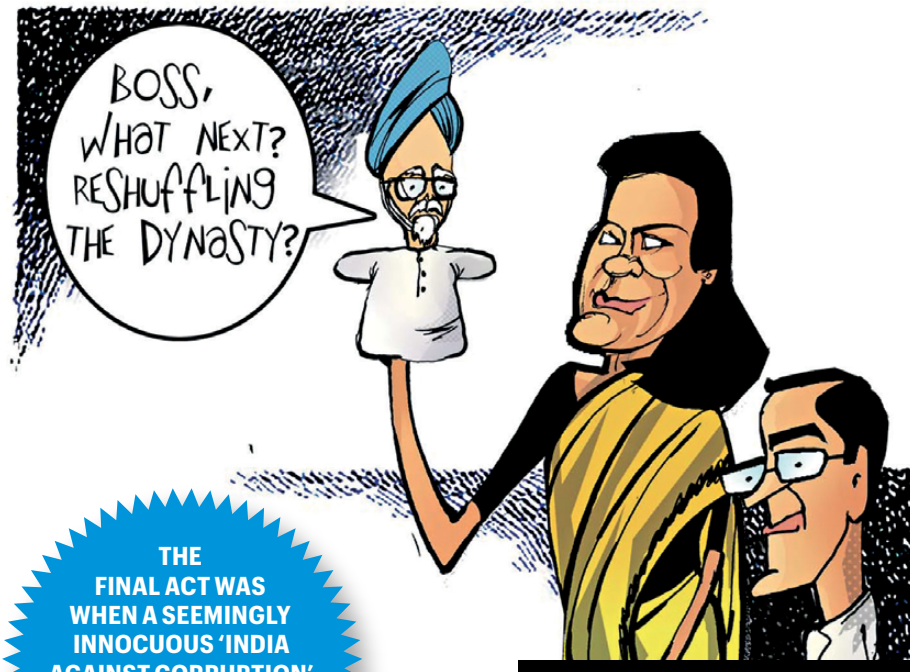


Congress on a Crutch
Aug. 22, 2011

"Many democratic governments have been killed by 'stag-flation', stagnation in growth combined with inflation. UPA 2 is suffering from an attack of 'stinkfla-tion', a combination of stinking corruption and inflationary prices that is potentially fatal."



Cartoons by Ravi Shankar, Feb. 13, 2006 and (below) May 30, 2005

THE FINAL ACT WAS WHEN A SEEMINGLY INNOCUOUS 'INDIA AGAINST CORRUPTION' MOVEMENT IN 2011 TRIGGERED A WIDER ANTI-INCUMBENCY SENTIMENT

incumbency sentiment fuelled by a hyper-ventilating 24x7 media campaign. A semi-retired Gandhian activist, an ambitious media-savvy neta, a motley army of disenchanted citizens tacitly backed by an RSS machine pushed the Singh government over the brink. No single move exemplified the executive's loss of moral and political authority more than when senior UPA government ministers frantically rushed to the airport to fawningly receive the controversial yoga guru, Baba Ramdev, who had also hopped onto the anti-corruption bandwagon. The UPA's buckling to Ramdev was a sign of a fatal loss of nerve. "That is the day I knew we had completely lost the plot," a cabinet minister confessed. When Rahul Gandhi was anointed as heir apparent ahead of the 2014 election, the die had been cast. Having chosen to turn down the opportunity to be a minister in the UPA 2 government, the fifth-generation dynast was clearly a reluctant power politician, ill-suited to shepherd a flailing party in desperate need of a momentum switch.

Paradoxically, even as the Congress-led government nosedived into free fall, the BJP found its knight in shining armour. Its original ideological mascot, an ageing L.K. Advani, was no longer an attractive option, but Gujarat chief minister Narendra Modi, an RSS pracharak-turned-politician nurtured by him, emerged as the new talisman. Driven by an obsessive personality cult, Modi was a populist nationalist who claimed to have a 56-inch chest. He had become a divisive Hindutva hero of the 2002 Gujarat riots before turning into a dream merchant of 'vikas' (development). Now, the 63-year-old Modi stepped in as the 'strongman' of the moment. The loud, bombastic, larger-than-life Modi was the polar opposite of Dr Singh and Rahul Gandhi. The silent bureaucrat-politician's troubled legacy and the politics of inheritance symbolised by the Gandhi surname versus the rumbustious anti-establishment demagogue who had risen by his 'chaiwallah' bootstraps, it was a no-contest. Modi was there at the right place at the right time to capture the zeitgeist of the moment with artful choreography.

'Hopefully, history will judge me kindly,' remarked Dr Singh in one of his last media interactions in 2014. It was the lament of a forlorn-looking public figure who had little left to offer. An uncertain decade that was arguably the Republic's last connect with a broader Nehruvian consensus was coming to a decisive but almost inevitable end. India was ready to be Modi-fied. ■



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